EVHYBRIDNOIRE

CLAFLIN UNIVERSITY

EVHybridNoire Fellowship Pipeline Program Capstone Project

Claflin University Students' Perspective on E-Mobility and Ways to Positively Influence It

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Introduction

The way people move from place to place is changing in meaningful ways. E-mobility, which refers to electric transportation and the systems that support it, is changing the way communities, industries, and governments think about travel. With growing concerns around climate change, rising fuel prices, and long-term sustainability, both the public and private sectors are moving more aggressively toward cleaner energy options. But this shift goes beyond just new technology. At its core, it is a human story about who gets access to new innovations, who stands to benefit, and who risks being left behind.

In the United States, the move toward electric vehicles is gaining momentum, but it is not unfolding equally. While younger generations are showing strong interest in EVs, barriers such as limited charging infrastructure and limited public awareness continue to slow adoption. These challenges are felt most acutely in communities that have historically been overlooked, particularly Black Americans and other minority groups, where access to clean transportation options and clean energy careers remains disproportionately limited.

College students, especially those attending Historically Black Colleges and Universities (HBCUs) like Claflin University, occupy a distinct and important position in this conversation. As members of Generation Z, today's students tend to be more environmentally conscious and open to sustainable solutions than previous generations. Yet their ability to participate in the e-mobility transition, whether as consumers or future professionals, is shaped by real world factors including financial access, exposure to industry opportunities, and the availability of relevant education and career pathways. Understanding how students at HBCUs perceive and engage with e-mobility offers valuable insight into how this transition can be made more equitable and effective for everyone.

This paper examines Claflin University's perspective on e-mobility across four key areas: Generation Z perspectives on e-mobility, diversity in e-mobility career opportunities, diversity in electric vehicle adoption, and e-mobility's impact on community and city development. Building on existing research and student perspectives within the Claflin community, it identifies barriers to participation in the e-mobility sector and proposes actionable solutions to increase awareness, access, and opportunity not only at Claflin but across HBCUs and underrepresented communities nationwide.

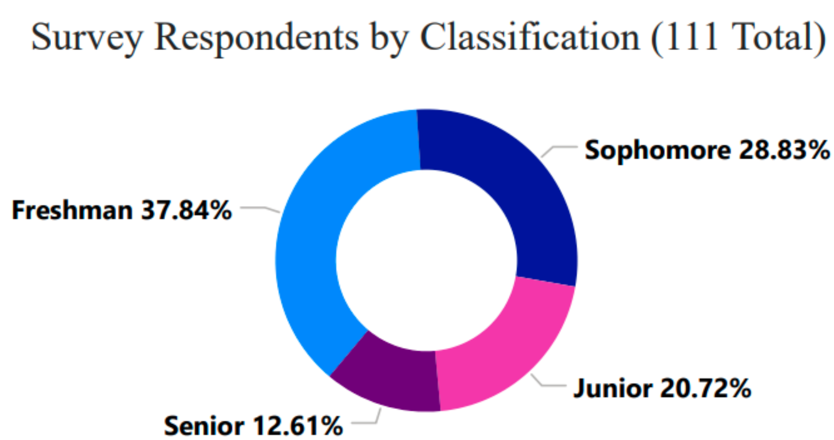
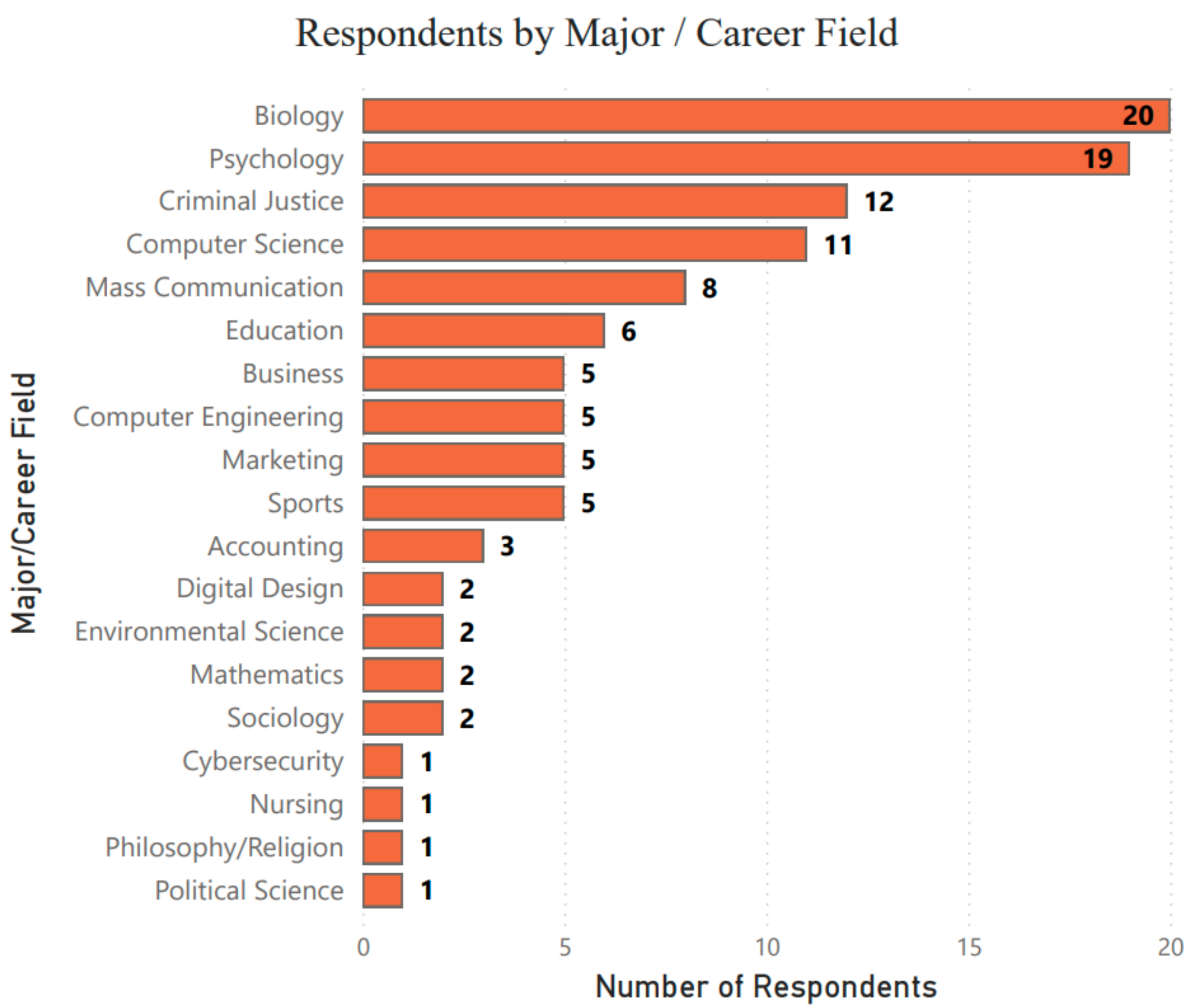


Figure 1



Respondents by Major / Career Field
Biology
Psychology
Criminal Justice
Computer Science
Mass Communication
Education
Business
Computer Engineering
Marketing
Sports
Accounting
Digital Design
Environmental Science
Mathematics
Sociology
Cybersecurity
Nursing
Philosophy/Religion
Political Science
20
19
12
11
8
6
5
5
5
5
3
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1
0
5
10
15
20
Number of Respondents
Major/Career Field

Figure 2

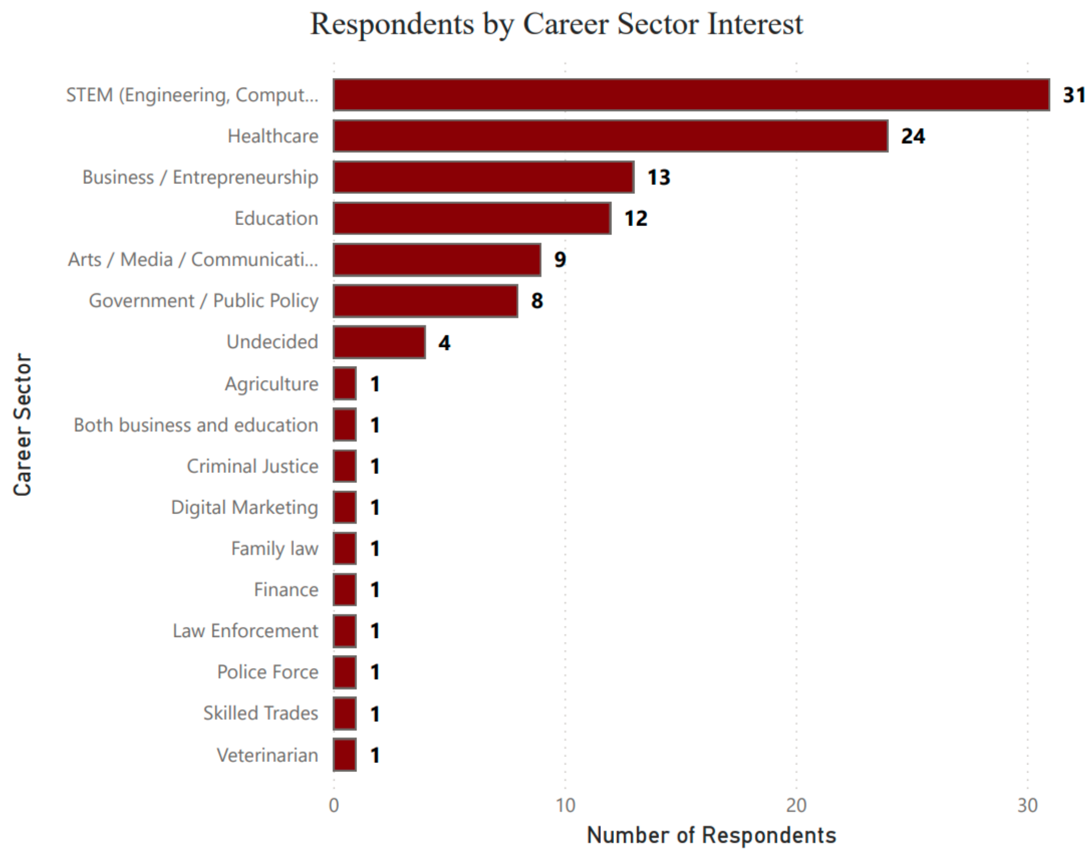

Figure 3

A survey was prepared and distributed to Claflin University students at random containing quantitative and qualitative questions with the objective of understanding their perspective of e-mobility. The student sample size totaled 111 with the spread being 37.84% freshman, 28.83% sophomore, 20.72% junior and 12.61% senior. Regarding their major, 20 of the 111 were Biology, 19 studied Psychology, 12 Criminal Justice, 11 Computer Science and the rest spread out between 14 other majors. Nearly 30% of respondents are interested in pursuing a career in STEM (31), while 24 chose Healthcare, 13 Business/Entrepreneurship and the rest distributed among 14 other options.

Generation Z’s Perspective on E-Mobility

Generation Z is often regarded as one of the most environmentally conscious generations, a claim supported by multiple studies. According to the 2024 global survey conducted by Deloitte, 62% of Gen Z respondents reported feeling anxious or concerned about climate change, while approximately 64% indicated a willingness to pay more for environmentally sustainable products and services (Deloitte, 2024). These behaviors suggest that sustainability plays a meaningful role in shaping Gen Z’s decisions, including their interest in cleaner transportation options such as electric vehicles, positioning them as an important group in the transition toward e-mobility. Despite this, Gen Z’s approach to electric vehicle adoption is shaped by a range of practical concerns. A 2024 survey highlighted by Newsweek found that about 41% of Gen Z respondents see themselves owning an electric vehicle in the future, compared to 34% of respondents overall (Newsweek, 2024).

However, this interest is limited by financial and structural barriers, as 56% of Gen Z report living paycheck to paycheck, restricting their ability to afford high-cost purchases such as vehicles (Deloitte, 2024). In addition to cost, access to charging infrastructure remains a major concern, with 38% of respondents identifying charging availability as an issue (Newsweek, 2024). These challenges are especially relevant for young adults living in apartments or shared housing, where private charging is often not an option, increasing reliance on public infrastructure that may not always be accessible or convenient.

Beyond cost and infrastructure, Gen Z evaluates electric vehicles differently from older generations. Their concerns are more evenly distributed across factors such as reliability, safety, design, and performance rather than focusing solely on price and driving range. At the same time, perceptions of the environmental benefits of electric vehicles appear to be declining. Recent survey data shows that the percentage of respondents who believe EVs are better for the environment dropped from 46% in 2022 to about one-third more recently (Newsweek, 2024). This suggests that economic factors and limited awareness continue to shape how we evaluate e-mobility. These patterns suggest that Gen Z's hesitation is not driven by a lack of interest, but by uncertainty and limited confidence in the current system. Similar trends can be seen in how Gen Z approaches the broader clean energy sector. Research from Environment+Energy Leader shows that while many young people are interested in sustainability-focused careers, participation is often limited by misconceptions about job requirements and a lack of awareness of available opportunities (E+E Leader, 2024).

Gen Z's perspective on e-mobility reflects strong environmental values balanced with practical hesitation. While this generation is more likely to support sustainable solutions, barriers related to cost, infrastructure, and access continue to slow adoption. Addressing these challenges will be essential in translating Gen Z's awareness into active participation in the transition to e-mobility.

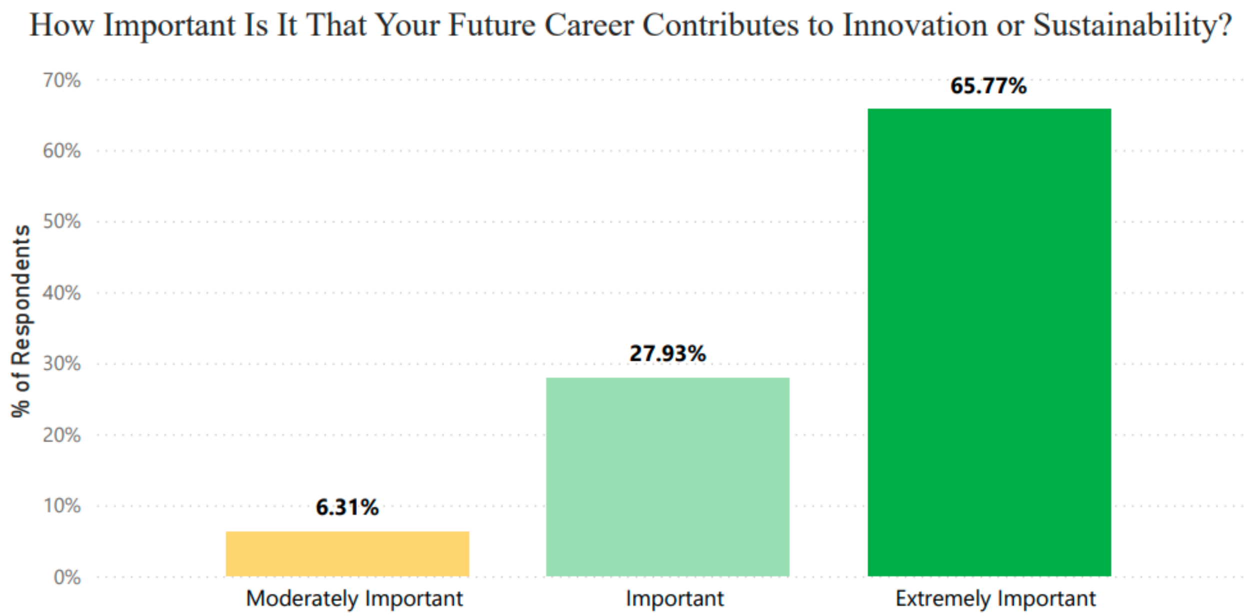

Figure 4

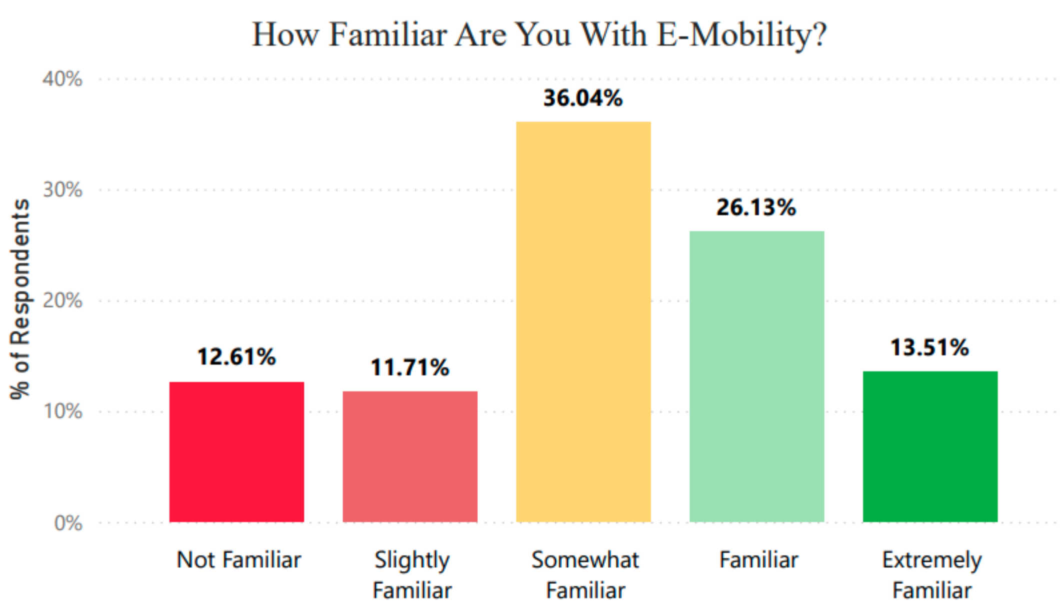

Figure 5

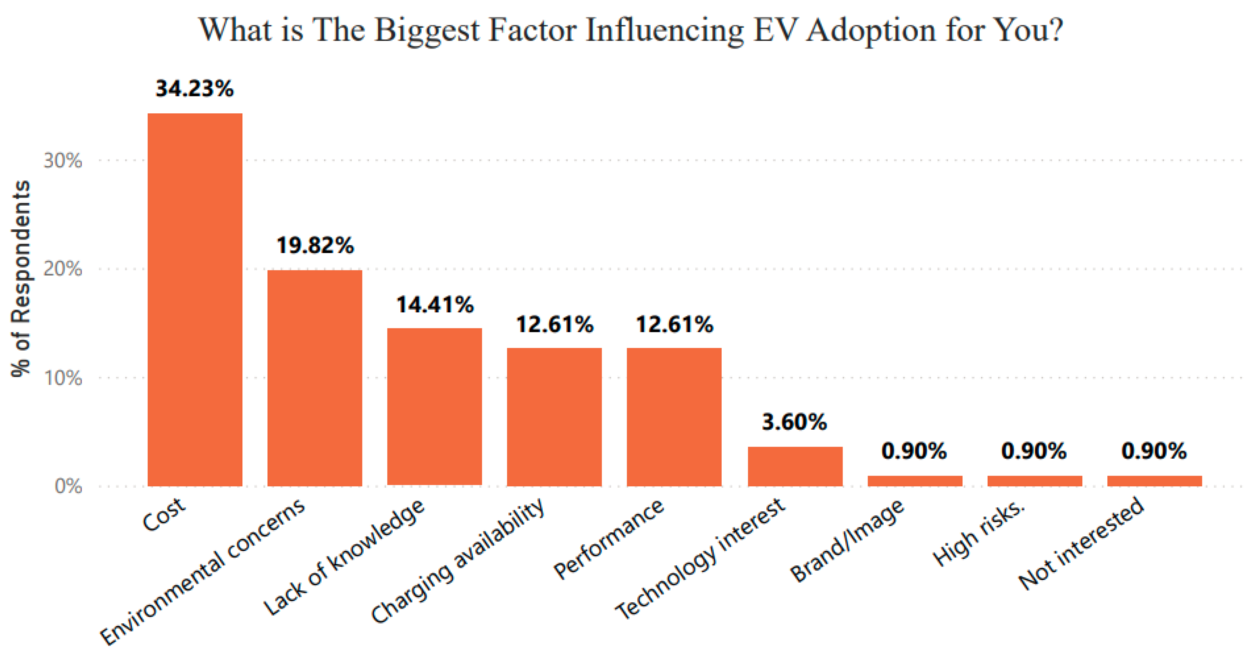

Figure 6

As per figure 4, Claflin students were asked the question, “How important is it that your future career contributes to innovation or sustainability?” Majority of the respondents believe that it is important that their careers contribute to sustainability. This echoes the same results shared in the study done by Deloitte in 2024. Figure 5 highlights what could be the disconnect between that belief and the real-world opportunities available to facilitate that desire. When asked, “How familiar are you with e-mobility?” 36.04% take a more neutral stance being ‘somewhat familiar’ while a combined 24.32% (11.71% and 12.61%) are even less familiar to having no knowledge of the industry at all. On the other hand, a total of 39.64% are in the camp of being more familiar to very knowledgeable. This shows an opportunity for growth and raising awareness among young Black Americans of what the e-mobility industry has to offer.

The Environment+Energy Leader 2024 research brought attention to the idea that Gen Z are concerned about a wide array of factors when deciding whether to adopt EVs or not, and this sentiment rings true with Claflin students as well. Figure 6 illustrates the responses for reasons influencing EV adoption. While the most selected reason is cost, being 34.23%, other factors are in the equation as well, other top factors include environmental concerns, lack of knowledge, charging availability and performance.

Diversity in E-Mobility Career Opportunities

The clean energy sector is one of the fastest-growing industries in the United States, and with that growth comes an expanding landscape of career opportunities that reaches well beyond the technical roles most people associate with it. The Ameresco "Empowered Futures" 2024 Clean Energy Career Report, based on a dedicated survey of 600 Gen Z and Millennial respondents conducted in August 2024, offers one of the most comprehensive looks at how young workers perceive and engage with clean energy careers. The report found that more than 80% of respondents view clean energy as a promising career path, and 88% stated that their career must align with their personal values, with many indicating that giving back through their work is just as important as earning a competitive salary.

The top reasons respondents were drawn to clean energy included environmental benefits (51%), strong growth potential (47%), and the desire to be part of something larger than themselves (43%). Among those already employed in other industries, 65% expressed a willingness to switch to a clean energy career, underscoring the breadth and genuineness of interest in this sector. Yet despite this enthusiasm, the report uncovered a persistent and damaging misconception: more than half of Gen Z respondents, including 59% who believe an engineering background is mandatory and 60% who believe a science degree is essential, do not realize that clean energy careers are available to people from a wide range of academic and professional backgrounds. From marketing and communications to policy, project management, community outreach, solar panel installation, wind turbine repair, and energy efficiency auditing, the sector offers meaningful and well-paying roles for individuals with business, social science, education, and liberal arts backgrounds. For students at Claflin University, many of whom are pursuing degrees outside traditional STEM fields, this misconception represents one of the greatest barriers standing between them and a career in an industry actively seeking diverse talent (Ameresco, 2024).

The infrastructure being built to support this growing workforce further strengthens the case for broader participation. According to the World Resources Institute's (WRI) 2024 analysis of emerging trends in the U.S. electric vehicle workforce, a growing number of four-year universities are expanding their EV-related research programs and academic offerings, while community colleges and vocational schools are rapidly developing certification programs and training tracks specifically designed to get students job-ready in a matter of months rather than years. These programs span a wide range of disciplines and skill levels, making entry into the e-mobility workforce increasingly accessible regardless of a student's starting point. WRI also notes that demand for EV-related talent is spreading well beyond vehicle manufacturing into areas such as grid modernization, software development, data analysis, supply chain management, and community engagement, underscoring the need for professionals who can think broadly, communicate effectively, and work across sectors. This shift is particularly significant for HBCUs like Claflin University, whose graduates are trained to do exactly that. As the educational pipeline into e-mobility expands and diversifies, institutions that proactively align their programming with these emerging needs will be best positioned to send their graduates into careers that are stable, impactful, and in high demand (WRI, 2024).

The urgency of building that pipeline becomes even clearer when the scale of projected industry growth is considered. The National Governors Association's EV Workforce Myth-Busting report (2025) projects that U.S. electric vehicle manufacturers will produce approximately 4.7 million vehicles annually by 2028, a figure that will drive sweeping demand for workers across every segment of the e-mobility ecosystem, including charging infrastructure installation, battery production, supply chain logistics, software engineering, fleet management, and customer education. The report also directly challenges the assumption that these careers require a four-year degree, making clear that short-term training programs, registered apprenticeships, and community college pathways offer legitimate and well-compensated entry points into the industry for students who may not follow a traditional academic route. Wages in these roles frequently exceed the national median by up to 25%, and positions commonly include health insurance and retirement benefits that set them apart from jobs in many other sectors.

Despite this, widespread public misunderstanding about who these careers are for continues to leave talented and motivated young people, particularly those from Black and minority communities, on the sidelines of an industry that needs them. For Claflin University, the combination of an accessible entry pathway, strong compensation, alignment with its student population's values, and a documented shortage of diverse talent creates a compelling and time-sensitive case for institutional investment in e-mobility education, outreach, and career development (NGA, 2025).

Do you believe E-Mobility can provide strong career opportunities for Black professionals?

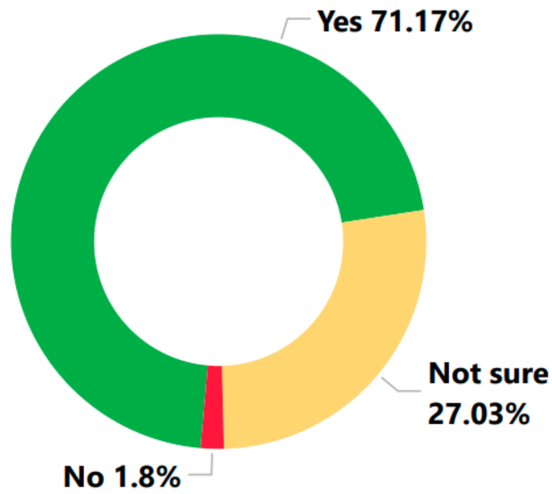

Figure 7

Would you consider working in the E-Mobility industry?

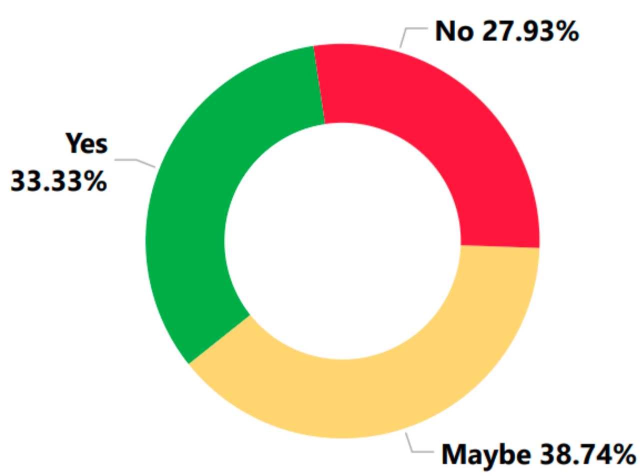

Figure 8

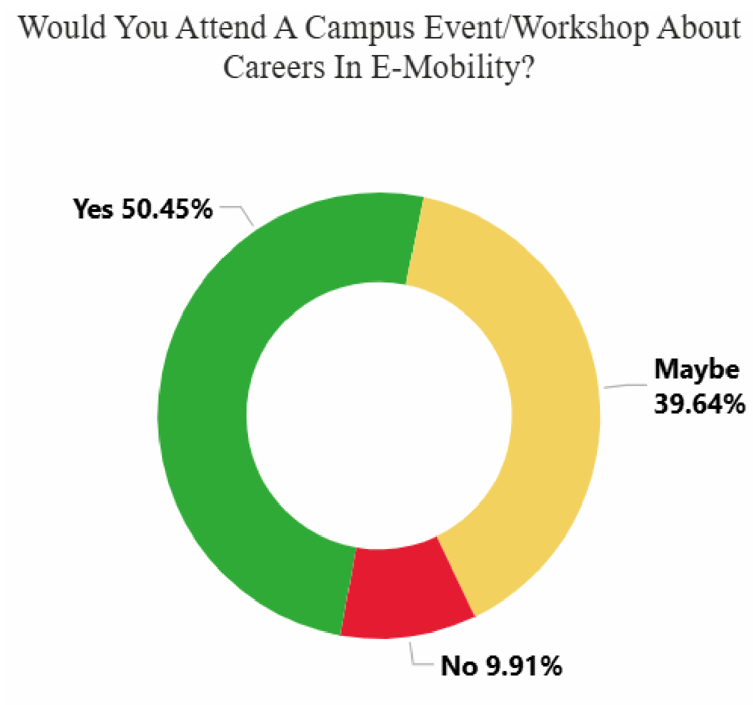

Figure 9

Most of Claflin University's respondents believe e-mobility can provide strong career opportunities for Black professionals, but only a third of them would confidently consider working in the industry themselves. This could possibly imply that while they do believe there is opportunity in the industry, based on their career aspirations they do not see that opportunity aligning with their interests. However, only 10% of respondents are not open to learning more about careers in e-mobility to possibly change their perspective on career opportunities for them in the industry. This is a positive sign.

(See Power BI dashboard 'Career' page [link found in Appendix] and use filtering by major to gain more insights)

Diversity in Electric Vehicle Adoption

While the transition to electric vehicles (EVs) is often presented as a universal shift toward sustainability, research shows that access to and adoption of EVs is not equal across all communities. Although interest in electric vehicles is strong across different racial and socioeconomic groups, systemic barriers continue to limit adoption among underrepresented populations. Research conducted by Consumer Reports in collaboration with EVNoire, GreenLatinos, and the Union of Concerned Scientists found that interest in purchasing electric vehicles is consistently high across racial demographics. However, structural inequalities such as lower average income levels and limited access to credit make it more difficult for many Black and Latino consumers to afford the higher upfront cost of EVs. This highlights a critical issue within the e-mobility transition. The challenge is not a lack of willingness to adopt electric vehicles, but unequal access to the resources needed to do so.

This disparity is further reflected in ownership data. A report from Capital B News indicates that Black Americans are significantly underrepresented among EV owners, accounting for only about 2% of electric vehicle ownership in the United States. This gap exists despite the fact that Black communities are often among those who would benefit most from reduced air pollution and improved environmental conditions associated with EV adoption. The report also notes that skepticism toward EVs within these communities is largely driven by concerns about affordability, infrastructure, and reliability, rather than a lack of interest in sustainability.

One of the most significant barriers contributing to this inequality is the uneven distribution of charging infrastructure. A 2024 study published in Nature Communications found that low-income and minority communities have significantly less access to public EV charging stations compared to higher-income and predominantly white areas. As a result, individuals in these communities often have to travel farther distances to access charging facilities, making EV ownership less convenient and less practical. This pattern is further illustrated in Figure 10, which shows that the distance to public charging stations decreases as income increases, with the gap becoming even more pronounced in rural areas. The figure also highlights that disparities exist across racial groups, reinforcing that access to infrastructure is shaped by both income and demographic factors (Lou et al., 2024).

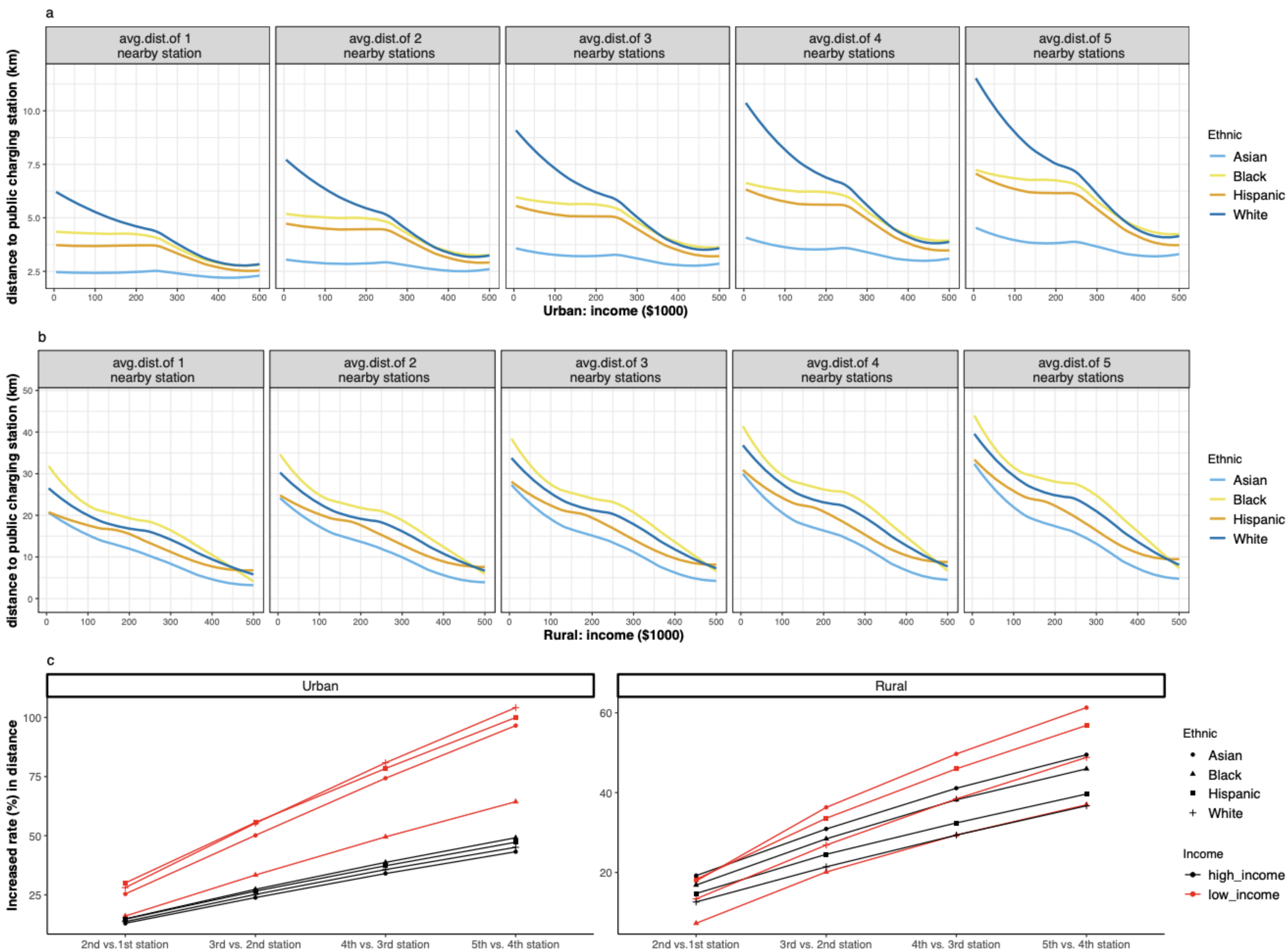

Figure 10. Nation-wide electric vehicle (EV) infrastructure accessibility gap

These disparities are closely tied to broader patterns of economic inequality and historical underinvestment in certain communities. Lower-income households are more likely to rely on used vehicles and face barriers when attempting to finance newer technologies such as EVs. At the same time, infrastructure investments have often been concentrated in wealthier areas, reinforcing existing inequalities in access to clean transportation. Overall, the research shows that diversity in

EV adoption is shaped less by individual preference and more by systemic factors. While interest in electric vehicles is widespread, barriers related to cost, infrastructure, and access continue to prevent equitable participation in the transition to e-mobility. Addressing these disparities will be essential to ensure that the benefits of electric transportation are shared across all communities.

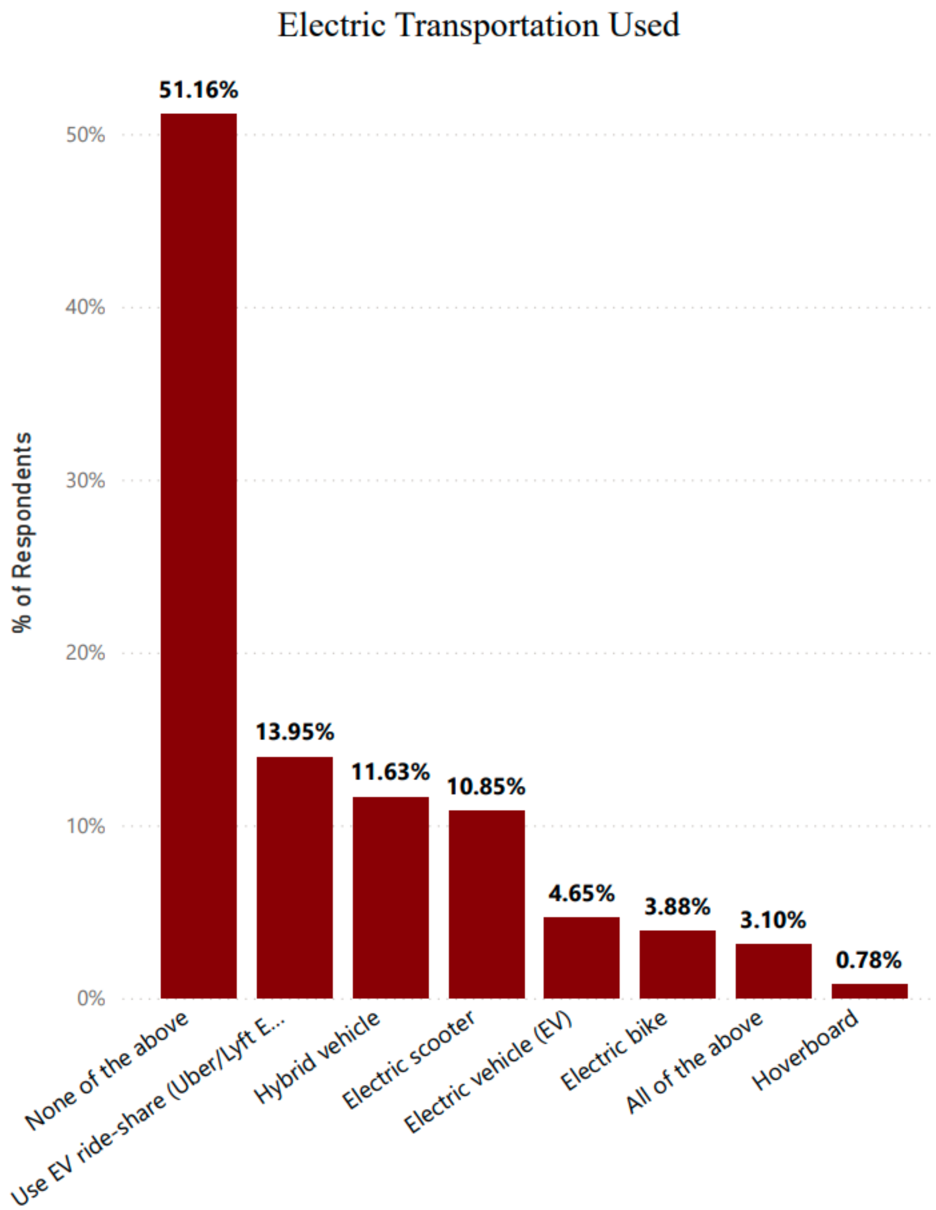
Electric Transportation Used
% of Respondents
50%
40%
30%
20%
10%
0%
51.16%
13.95%
11.63%
10.85%
4.65%
3.88%
3.10%
0.78%
None of the above
Use EV ride-share (Uber/Lyft E...
Hybrid vehicle
Electric scooter
Electric vehicle (EV)
Electric bike
All of the above
Hoverboard

Figure 11

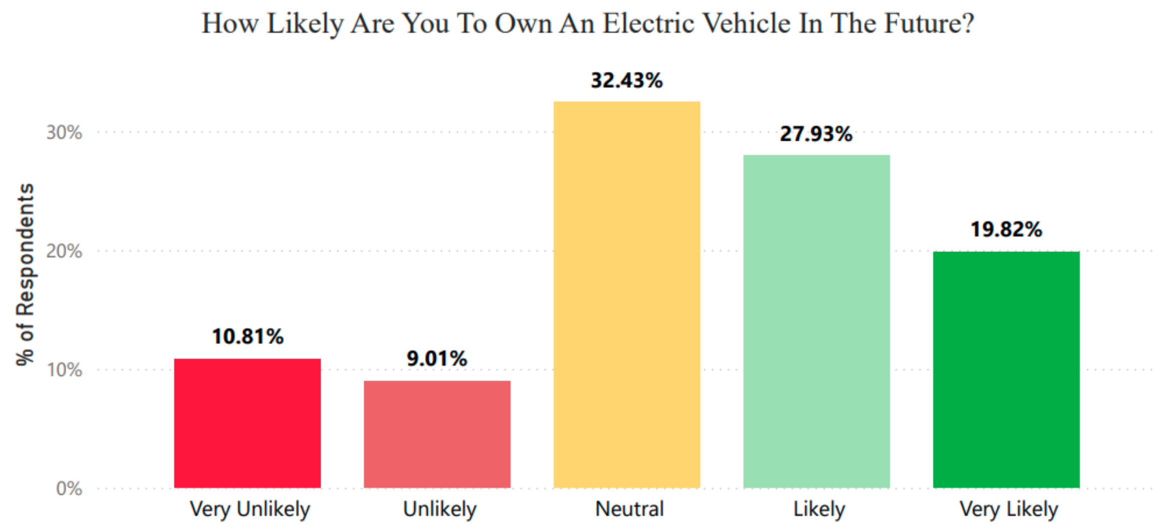

Figure 12

The consensus is clear that Gen Z and hence the Claflin University respondents are in support of promoting sustainability and EV adoption. However, figure 11 illustrates that most of the respondents do not currently use a form of electric transportation. This disconnect is supported by the Income & Racial Disparities in EV Infrastructure study in 2024. When questioned about the likelihood of owning an EV in the future, less than 20% gave a negative response. Most respondents expressed at least some level of interest in owning an EV, ranging from neutral to very likely, despite factors that may discourage EV adoption. We believe if there is a positive shift in how EVs and the industry as a whole is promoted toward minority groups and Black people specifically; there could be a significant shift in their perspective and EV adoption rates. Figure 6 illustrates what Claflin students deem to be their biggest factors influencing EV adoption. Similar to the research findings discussed earlier, cost is a major factor, selected by 34.23% respondents. There are other significant factors such as performance, charging availability, lack of knowledge and environmental concern. Most of these concerns can be addressed by raising awareness and sharing information.

E-Mobility's Impact on Community/City Development (Infrastructure)

The transition to e-mobility is significantly reshaping how communities and cities develop their infrastructure. As electric vehicles become more widely adopted, there is an increasing need for charging networks that are reliable, accessible, and strategically placed. According to the U.S. Department of Transportation, the development and placement of charging infrastructure is one of the most important factors influencing EV adoption, making it a central focus in transportation planning (USDOT, 2024). Building a strong network of charging stations across highways, neighborhoods, and commercial areas not only supports EV users but also encourages more individuals and businesses to consider electric transportation as a practical option.

Beyond transportation, the expansion of EV infrastructure contributes to broader community development. Investments in charging networks require coordination between governments, utilities, and private companies, which supports economic activity and infrastructure growth. Charging stations can also act as local economic drivers, as EV users often spend time at nearby businesses while charging. In addition, the U.S. Department of Transportation highlights that strategies such as smart charging and integrating EV-ready infrastructure into new developments allow communities to prepare for long-term growth while reducing future costs (USDOT, 2024).

E-mobility infrastructure also has important environmental and public health benefits. Electric vehicles produce zero tailpipe emissions, which helps reduce air pollution and improve overall air quality, particularly in communities that are disproportionately affected by transportation-related pollution. These benefits make e-mobility not only a transportation solution but also a public health improvement, especially in urban and underrepresented areas where exposure to emissions is often higher.

The impact of e-mobility is especially significant in rural communities, where infrastructure challenges are more pronounced. Although only about 20% of Americans live in rural areas, these regions account for approximately 68% of the nation's total road miles, meaning residents in these areas tend to travel longer distances more frequently, increasing fuel consumption and making the environmental benefits of electric vehicles more significant (Bureau of Transportation Statistics, 2025). Since rural drivers tend to travel longer distances and spend more on fuel, the lower operating costs of EVs can provide meaningful financial benefits over time. Expanding charging infrastructure in these areas can also support economic development by attracting travelers and increasing activity at local businesses. The way EV infrastructure is planned and distributed plays a key role in shaping accessibility, economic opportunity, and quality of life across both urban and rural communities (USDOT, 2025).

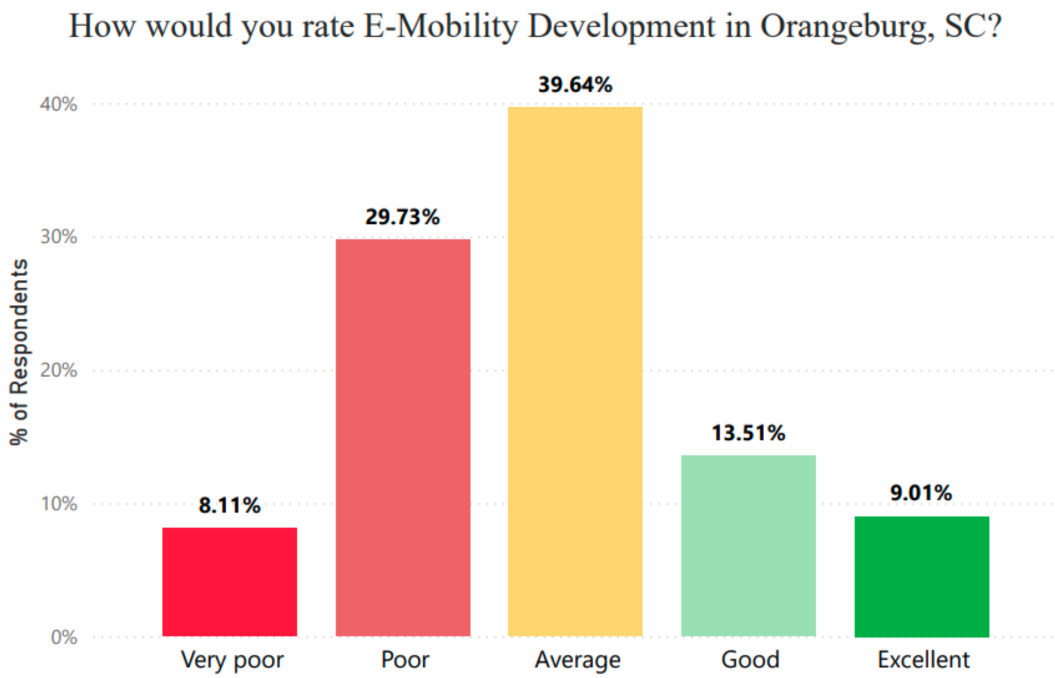

Figure 13

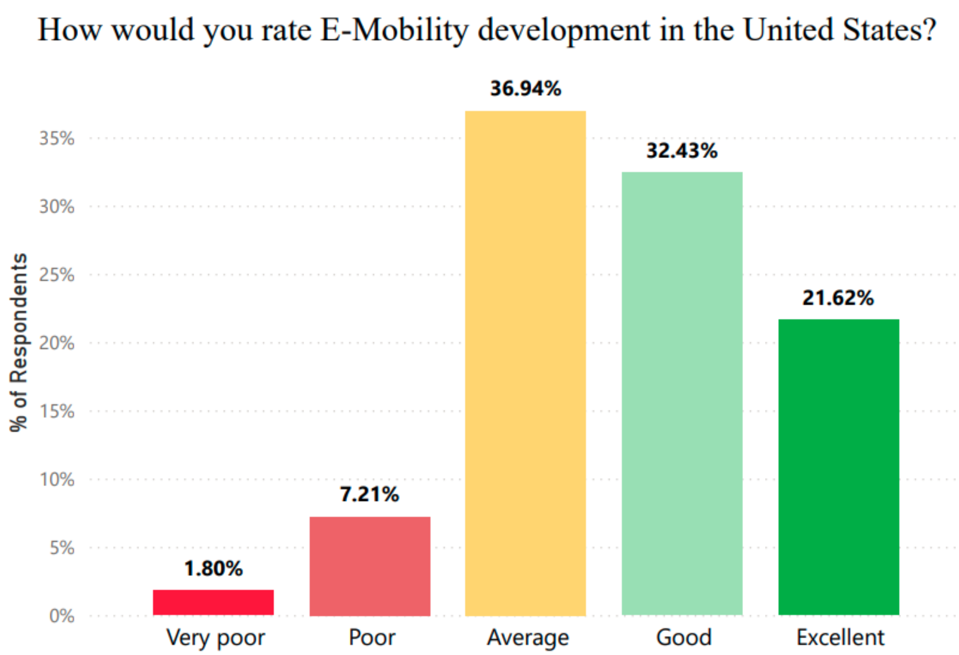

Figure 14

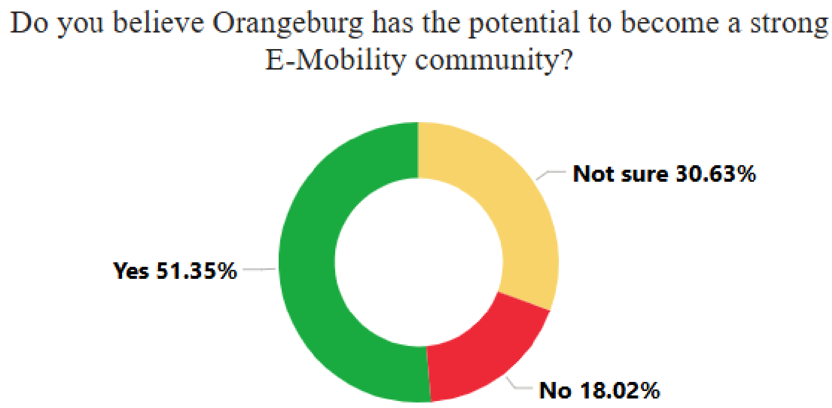

Figure 15

When asked to rate e-mobility development, both in Orangeburg, SC (home to Claflin University) and across the wider United States, respondents most commonly selected "Average" for both, placing each squarely in the middle of the scale. However, a closer look at the distribution reveals a meaningful difference between the two. Ratings for the United States skewed positive, with "Good" and "Excellent" emerging as the second and third most selected options, respectively. Ratings for Orangeburg told a different story: "Poor" was the second most common response, suggesting that while respondents view national e-mobility progress relatively favorably, many see their local community as falling behind.

When asked about their confidence in Orangeburg's potential to grow into a strong e-mobility community, the outlook was more encouraging. More than half of respondents expressed optimism, while approximately 30% remained uncertain. Only 18% responded negatively. These results suggest that most students believe their community is capable of rising to meet the demands of an electrified future, and that the roughly one-in-three who are undecided or skeptical may simply need better access to information, resources, and visible local progress to bring them on board.

Conclusion & Recommendations

The findings from this study highlight an important gap between interest and participation in e-mobility among Claflin University students, reflecting broader trends seen across Generation Z and underrepresented communities. While students demonstrated a strong commitment to sustainability and expressed interest in electric vehicles, this interest is often limited by practical barriers such as cost, limited infrastructure, and lack of familiarity. These results mirror existing research, which shows that adoption is not driven by a lack of willingness, but by structural challenges that make access to e-mobility more difficult for many communities.

Addressing this gap requires a more targeted and community-centered approach. Research shows that one of the most effective ways to promote e-mobility in underrepresented communities is through direct engagement and education. Programs that actively involve communities in discussions, provide clear information about incentives, and create opportunities for hands-on experiences, such as ride-and-drive events, can significantly increase awareness and confidence in electric vehicles (Center for Sustainable Energy, 2026). This is especially important for Gen Z populations, who may be interested in sustainability but lack exposure to how e-mobility fits into their daily lives or future careers.

In addition to awareness, improving accessibility is critical. Financial barriers remain one of the most significant obstacles to adoption, particularly for lower-income and underrepresented communities. Studies show that purchase incentives, rebates, and programs focused on used electric vehicles can significantly increase adoption rates by making EVs more affordable (Clinton & Steinberg, 2019). Expanding charging infrastructure in underserved areas is equally important, as limited access to charging stations continues to discourage potential users. Ensuring that infrastructure is placed in communities that have historically been overlooked is essential for creating a more equitable transition.

Community-based solutions also play a key role in shaping perceptions and increasing participation. Initiatives such as EV car-sharing programs, partnerships with local businesses, and the installation of charging stations in public spaces like schools and community centers have been shown to improve access and reduce barriers to adoption (Envoy Technologies, 2023). These approaches are particularly effective in communities where individuals may not have the financial means or physical space to own a personal vehicle, allowing more people to experience e-mobility without full ownership.

Finally, increasing representation within the e-mobility and clean energy workforce is essential for long-term change. When individuals from underrepresented backgrounds, including Black communities, are actively involved in the development and promotion of e-mobility solutions, it builds trust and ensures that these systems are designed with diverse needs in mind. Creating clearer pathways into clean energy careers through education, internships, and community programs can help Gen Z see themselves as participants in the industry rather than just consumers.

In conclusion, the transition to e-mobility must be approached not only as a technological shift, but as a community-driven effort. The findings from Claflin University demonstrate that interest in sustainability already exists, but meaningful participation will depend on addressing barriers related to cost, infrastructure, awareness, and representation. By focusing on these areas, institutions like Claflin University can play a key role in shaping how Generation Z and underrepresented communities engage with and benefit from the future of e-mobility.

Limitations

There are some limitations to consider as you interpret the results of the survey conducted among Claflin University's students. There are approximately 1800 to 2000 students at Claflin University. For this population size, the standard sample size would be approximately 16-18% of the population. Our sample size captured between 5.55-6.17% of the population. This means we cannot be overconfident in the results, but they still paint a picture.

Of the 111 respondents, when separated by classification, the strongest disparity is between freshmen and seniors, being 37.84% and 12.61% respectively. Freshmen are more likely less exposed to the Orangeburg city and other things like opportunities for owning an electric vehicle. There is also a higher density of Biology and Psychology majors, totaling 20 and 19 respectively. The rest are generally more spread out. Using the filter option on the Power BI 'Career' page reveals that these students are heavily skewed towards not pursuing or believing there is a career in e-mobility and since they make up a significant portion of the dataset, they can heavily influence it in comparison to other majors independently.

Qualitative data was collected, however those results were not quantifiable and could not be graphically represented. This data can be accessed through a link to the survey data provided in the Appendix section. Finally, it is implied in the discussion of the results that all the respondents of the survey are Gen Z, but age data was not collected to verify that, only an assumption based on real-time observation and a demographic of Claflin University students being predominantly Gen Z.

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Appendix

Survey administered to Claflin University Students [PDF]: SURVEY_FORM_DISTRIBUTED

Survey Data Excel File (Cleaned and edited to remove PII of respondents): EXCEL_DATA

View E-Mobility Capstone Project Power BI Report View: POWER_BI_REPORT_WEBPAGE

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